

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance School of the Year

Dance School of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Clear, specific achievements from the past year and why they matter.
- Evidence of positive impact on students, staff, or the wider community.
- A clearly articulated ethos and set of values.
- Thoughtful support for students with different goals and pathways.
- Clear safeguarding procedures embedded in everyday practice.
- Awareness of student wellbeing and duty of care.
- Evidence of commitment to equity, diversity, and inclusion in policies, practice, and culture.
- Strong leadership and professional standards.
- A compelling overall case for why the school stands out.

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Eleanor Clark Dance Company

1. Tell us 3 things you are most proud of your school achieving in the last year. *

1. Building a thriving school without compromising our values

Since opening in June 2025, Eleanor Clark Dance Company has grown from 10 classes across two days to 29 classes across four days, with enrolment trebling between July 2025 and March 2026. This growth has been achieved organically through reputation, parent referrals, and the experience we provide, rather than through paid advertising. I am incredibly proud that we have built a sustainable, successful business while protecting the small class sizes, individual attention, and personal relationships that are central to our ethos.

2. Achieving exceptional outcomes across both technical and vocational pathways

Our students achieved 100% Distinctions and High Merits in Imperial Society of Teachers of Dancing examinations, alongside extraordinary competitive success, including being named Overall Most Outstanding Dance School and Overall Winners five times in 2026 at Regional Heats and National Finals, as well as receiving Golden Buzzers, Judges' Choice, Originality, and Overall Performance Awards. Students have also performed at MOVE IT and accessed scholarships and opportunities with leading vocational institutions including Laine Theatre Arts, Performers College, Miskin Theatre, and PUSH. These achievements demonstrate that our commitment to wellbeing does not limit ambition - it creates the confidence and foundations for students to excel.

3. Creating a culture where children genuinely feel safe, valued, and able to thrive

My proudest achievement is the culture we have created. From the very beginning, I wanted to build a school where children could experience the highest standards of dance training without feeling that they had to compromise their confidence, individuality, or wellbeing in order to succeed. ECDC was founded on the belief that dance should build children up, not break them down, and I am proud that this is reflected in the experiences of our students and families. Parents have described ECDC as their child's "happy place", a "safe place and trusted person", and a source of stability during incredibly difficult circumstances.

In just one year, we have created a community where students are encouraged to be themselves, where neurodiversity is understood and embraced, and where effort, resilience, kindness, and personal progress are valued alongside awards and results. Our first regional competition was particularly meaningful to me, as ECDC was recognised not only for our students' performances, but for our kindness and generosity. To see our values recognised outside the studio so early in our journey was incredibly powerful.

That culture is now visible in every aspect of the school: in the way students support one another, in the way they are encouraged to take risks and learn from mistakes, and in the trust families place in us to care for their children. We have created more than a place to learn dance; we have created a genuine community of belonging.

For me, this achievement matters most because it demonstrates that the success of a dance school should not be measured only by trophies, examination results, or growth figures. It should also be measured by the kind of people we help young dancers become, and by the environment we create for them along the way.

We have demonstrated that a school can pursue exceptional technical standards while also protecting children's confidence, wellbeing, individuality, and joy - proving that excellence and humanity can, and should, exist side by side.

2. How would you describe your school's ethos and values? *

Eleanor Clark Dance Company's ethos can be summed up simply: every child matters, just as they are.

ECDC was founded with the belief that technical excellence and emotional wellbeing should never be competing priorities. They are partners. We want our students to become accomplished dancers, but we also want them to become confident, resilient, kind, creative young people who feel secure in who they are.

Our values are rooted in kindness, inclusion, individuality, integrity, ambition, and belonging. We actively challenge the pressure and exclusivity that can exist within dance training, creating an environment where students are encouraged to take risks, make mistakes, ask questions, and try again without fear of judgement.

We celebrate effort alongside achievement and progress alongside outcome. Students are not expected to fit one mould; teaching is adapted to individual learning styles, personalities, abilities, and goals. Neurodiversity is understood and embraced, not simply accommodated. Every dancer is supported to shine in their own way.

Our culture is built on the belief that a child should never have to sacrifice their wellbeing in order to achieve. We hold high expectations, but we deliver them with compassion. We encourage ambition without comparison, discipline without fear, and excellence without compromising emotional safety.

As a founder-led school, these values are not simply words on a website. I teach every class myself, meaning they are embedded directly into the everyday experience of every student. I know my dancers as individuals: their strengths, their challenges, their personalities, their goals, and the ways in which they learn best.

Ultimately, ECDC is more than movement. It is a place of belonging. A place where children feel seen, heard, celebrated, and supported - and where they can fall in love with dance without ever feeling that they have to lose themselves to succeed.

3. How do you support both recreational and aspiring professional students? *

At Eleanor Clark Dance Company, we believe every student deserves the same level of care, regardless of where they want dance to take them.

For recreational students, dance is about joy, confidence, creativity, friendship, and personal development. We create opportunities for every child to perform, participate, and experience the excitement of dance without pressure to pursue a professional pathway. Students are encouraged to progress at their own pace, with success measured not only through examinations or awards, but through the confidence they gain and the joy they find in moving.

For students who aspire to professional careers, we provide clear progression opportunities alongside the same wellbeing-first ethos. Students can access structured ISTD examination pathways, competitive performance opportunities, workshops, auditions, industry exposure, and vocational preparation. We have supported students towards scholarships and training opportunities at institutions including Laine Theatre Arts, Performers College, Miskin Theatre, and PUSH, helping them understand and navigate the next steps in their development.

Our approach is highly individualised. Not every aspiring professional needs the same pathway, just as not every recreational dancer wants the same experience. We take the time to understand each student's goals and adapt our support accordingly.

Importantly, we never define a student's worth by their potential career in dance. A student who dances simply because it makes them happy is valued just as highly as one who dreams of performing professionally.

This is central to our ethos: ambition is encouraged, but never imposed. We challenge students to reach their potential while ensuring they remain emotionally supported throughout the process. Whether a child dances for fun, friendship, confidence, competition, examinations, or a future career, they should leave ECDC feeling proud of who they are and excited about what they can achieve.

4. What does safe guarding and student wellbeing look like in practice at your school? *

At Eleanor Clark Dance Company, safeguarding and student wellbeing are not separate from dance training - they are fundamental to it. Creating a safe environment is not simply one of our values; it is a non-negotiable responsibility.

As a founder-led school, I take a highly personal approach to knowing and understanding every student. I create an environment where children feel able to communicate, ask for help, and share concerns, while maintaining clear professional boundaries and appropriate safeguarding procedures. Students are treated with dignity and respect, and their individual needs, circumstances, and vulnerabilities are considered in how we teach and support them.

Safeguarding is embedded into everyday practice through DBS-checked staff, safeguarding training, a designated safeguarding lead, clear reporting procedures, risk assessments, registers and emergency procedures. We maintain appropriate communication with parents and carers and ensure that concerns are taken seriously, recorded, and escalated through the correct channels where necessary.

Wellbeing is equally central to the student experience. I pay close attention to changes in behaviour, confidence, engagement, and emotional presentation, recognising that a child may communicate that they are struggling through changes in behaviour rather than words. Students are encouraged to speak openly, and I work collaboratively with families when additional support may be needed.

Our approach to wellbeing also extends to the culture of training itself. We do not use humiliation, fear, or comparison as teaching tools. Students are allowed to make mistakes, ask questions, and try again. Effort is recognised alongside achievement, and teaching is adapted to different learning styles and neurodiverse needs.

We also recognise our duty of care when supporting ambitious young dancers. We encourage progression without placing inappropriate pressure on children, ensuring that competition, examinations, and vocational aspirations remain balanced with enjoyment, development, and emotional health.

The result is a culture where children know that they are safe, valued, and listened to. As one seven-year-old student put it: "Even if I don't get something right the first time, Eleanor never makes me feel bad - just proud for trying."

That, to me, is what safeguarding and wellbeing should look like in practice... not simply responding when something goes wrong, but creating an environment designed to help children feel safe enough to thrive every day.

5. Why do you believe your school deserves this award? *

I believe Eleanor Clark Dance Company deserves the Dance School of the Year award because we are demonstrating that a dance school can achieve exceptional standards without compromising the wellbeing of the children it serves.

In just one year, ECDC has grown from 10 classes across two days to 29 classes across four days, with enrolment trebling and net profit per teaching hour increasing by more than 110%. Our students have achieved 100% Distinctions and High Merits in ISTD examinations, been named Overall Most Outstanding Dance School and Overall Winners at competitions five times in 2026, performed at MOVE IT, accessed leading vocational pathways, and achieved recognition across competitions and performance platforms.

But the numbers are only one part of our story.

What makes ECDC stand out is the culture behind those achievements. We have built a school where technical excellence and emotional wellbeing are treated as equal priorities; where neurodiversity is understood; where recreational dancers are valued as highly as aspiring professionals; where children are encouraged to be ambitious without being pressured; and where kindness is considered a strength.

Our impact can be seen in the lives of the families we support. One parent shared that, during one of the most difficult times in their lives while undergoing treatment for cancer, ECDC became "not just a teacher, but a safe place and trusted person" for their child. They described the compassion, consistency, and support their child received as providing "a sense of normalcy and emotional security that made an immeasurable difference." This is the kind of impact that reminds me why ECDC exists: to be a place where children feel safe, supported, and able to thrive, whatever life may bring.

I founded this school after experiencing first-hand the ways in which dance can sometimes fail young people. I wanted to build something different: a school where children can work hard, dream big, and achieve extraordinary things while still feeling safe, seen, and celebrated.

ECDC is still young, but its impact is already significant. We are proving that excellence and humanity can coexist, and that the strongest foundations for ambitious dancers are not fear or pressure, but trust, belonging, and belief.

For me, Dance School of the Year would recognise not only what ECDC has achieved, but what it represents: a commitment to changing how children experience dance, for good.

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